

Despair

"If we can recognize that we don't know what will happen, that the future does not yet exist but is being made in the present, then we can be moved to participate in making the future. We can be skillful enough to make directed efforts and sophisticated enough to know that results remain unpredictable....learning to look for and value slow and indirect consequences is crucial to recognizing the nature of change." ("Despair is Luxury", *No Straight Road Takes You There – Essays for Uneven Terrain*, Rebecca Solnit)

As 2026 starts I'm reflecting not on new beginnings, but endings in recent memory. In that essay Solnit's notes on the most privileged attitude towards our climate future, despair, pulled me back into moments with it. For me those deep moments of despair were all about love. More specifically, the loss of love, love not fully spent, and love that I'd missed, or hadn't given my full attention.

A specific example is the despair felt after hearing the news of my dad's cancer. In my sophomore year of college I was returning a missed call from him on my walk from the dining hall to our football team meeting – we'd watch film from today's practice and note any adjustments for tomorrow's 6:40 AM session. Dad knew my lunchtime routine, a quick stop to the dining hall then over to meetings, so I figured the call was urgent. And after my last football game we'd all noticed a yellow tinge to his eyes, but he'd told us all they just felt dry from the wind. I didn't connect the dots to prepare myself before calling back. I could hear some pain in his voice, and I remember my mom being in the background, as if they were delivering the news together. He said they'd found a growth in his stomach, had suspicions it was cancer, but needed to run some more tests to determine the extent of it. The news took my wind, like I'd been on the receiving end of a block I hadn't seen coming, left unable to muster words in response to those concerned I'd been seriously hurt. I don't remember how I eventually responded when my voice came back.

I was hopeless about losing him, my guide, critic, best friend up to that point in my life. There was a lot I'd hoped to share with him over the next few years – becoming a great college athlete, maybe continuing my baseball career afterwards, or becoming a great soldier, swapping stories like he did with his friends. Becoming a good father, like he was to me. But in my despair that future didn't exist, those moments no longer shared.

I went home for a few days, joining friends and family in that despair, then returned to campus, trying to live life as if we didn't know the outcome of his cancer – like the future was uncertain, even though it wasn't. Sometimes the despair peaked out, once in a meeting with my strength coach as he questioned my tardiness to an early morning team lift. I framed my effort to go on living life as a way to fill up my dad's final time with things he could be proud of. I finished college and considered grad schools and potential career paths in the military, him joining me on visits to campuses and meetings with Marine Corps and Army recruiters. He did live much longer than doctors told us we could expect. They'd said 6 months but it was 6 years. One of my most vivid memories during those final years is a trip we took to New York together to visit NYU,

Columbia, Cornell, grad schools I was considering. I was depressed at that time, from another heartbreak. But sharing that trip with him was special. His love so tangible, hopefully mine too. In spite of my depression, I'm glad we shared that. His excitement for my future subbed in for my own.

"What motivates us to act is a sense of possibility within uncertainty – a sense that the outcome is not yet fully determined and our actions may matter in shaping it. (also Solnit)

I went on living, loving, in spite of that pain. That was my first trial with despair, but not my last. The despair I feel now only scares me because I'm convinced it's bound to happen again. Even as I get through this bout, do I have to get through another, a few months or years down the line? That's what leaves me unsure the future is worth the current suffering. I have resilience, toughness, but I feel too deeply to keep repeating moments like this.

Originally some defensiveness to Solnit's thesis triggered this reflection. Despair isn't always so privileged. But I do think I'm privileged to feel so deeply, to feel the full spectrum of emotions, even the most painful. I don't look forward to a future without more of these problems, because each of these old heartbreaks is permanent, bound to revisit me. Despair will always be there for me, waiting, unsolvable. It's deeper than Solnit's examples of climate change outrage, but leaves me defeated, just the same.